

PITCH — CG — VERDICT

ADJUDICATED 2026-09-16 — WATCH — pre-event print (conviction 7/10). The court found nothing to own at this price; the reopen gates below are the only path back.

What we believe

Carlyle's stock has fallen 37% from its 52-week high (pack tape: \$43.105 vs \$68.4603 high, \$39.60 low — so we are only 8.9% above the low). The market is treating Carlyle as if a private-credit accident is already inside its earnings. We believe two things:

1. **The fee business has not been measured since the damage.** The last real fee print is the Q2'26 10-Q filed 2026-08-10 (<https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/0001527166/000152716626000045/cg-20260630.htm>), which predates the September dislocation. In that print the credit fee line was *accelerating*, not decaying: Global Credit fee-related earnings ran \$138mm vs \$111mm a year earlier (+24%), and the implied fee rate on credit assets rose from ~21.9bps to ~26.2bps. So the thing the bear story is about had, at last look, gotten better.
2. **The price embeds target failure.** At \$43.105 against management's 2028 deal-earnings-per-share target of \$6.00, we are paying 7.18x a three-year-out number. That is a discount for the target missing, not a price that assumes it is met.

What we do **not** believe is that we have proven the damage is absent. The honest class for this name, adopted by both benches, is **DAMAGE-UNMEASURED (pre-event print)**. We are buying a small amount of a cheap manager ahead of the first venue that can tell us anything, and we are paying for the right to learn.

What the market believes

The market believes Carlyle is a leveraged bet on private credit at exactly the wrong moment, and it has evidence:

- Carlyle's own listed lending vehicle, CGBD, printed net asset value per share of \$15.61 at 6/30/26 — down from \$15.89 and \$16.26 before it, three declines in a row (−4.0%), with two new non-accruals and net investment income covering the (already cut) dividend at exactly 1.00x (<https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/0001544206/000154420626000055/csl-20260630.htm>).
- Headline assets rose faster than *fee-paying* assets in Q2'26 (AUM +4% to \$485bn vs fee-earning AUM +3% to \$334bn; 68.9% fee-bearing and falling), and a record \$28bn of “pending” fee-earning AUM is explicitly not billing yet.
- The marginal seller is still working: we are 8.9% off the low, not 30% off it.

And critically: **this long is not a new idea**. A street note on 2026-05-31 argued the same thing we are arguing — limited private-credit exposure, ~11x, fair value in the mid-\$60s, buy — and the stock has since lost about a third. We are not early. We are the same trade, later and cheaper.

Why we might have edge

- **Timing, not information.** Our edge is that the first post-dislocation fee print lands 2026-10-29 and nobody — including us — has the numbers. Buying a 7.2x multiple *before* the measurement, in small size, is a different trade from buying an 11x multiple in May.
- **One real analytic correction.** The bear “fee base is decaying” story is mostly an accounting artifact. Fee-earning AUM is struck on committed/invested **cost**; total AUM carries **fair value**. When the portfolio appreciates, the fee-bearing *ratio* mechanically falls even though nothing has decayed. Corporate Private Equity AUM –1% is late-life fee step-down, which is what a harvesting fund looks like. Our Blue bench caught this and it overturned Red’s headline attack.
- **The insider cluster is benign.** Eight Form 4s from eight different filers on the same day (2026-08-28), eighteen days after an S-8 comp-plan registration, is a scheduled vest — not distribution, and not a forced seller.

Why it might be priced in

- **The consensus objection stands as a sizing instrument.** Neither bench could produce a single consensus estimate for the metric our thesis rests on (Q3 Global Credit FRE $\geq$ \$138mm). We therefore cannot show our number is above the street’s — we only know the street liked the stock at \$60+ and the stock is \$43.
- **The cheapness may be correctly cheap.** 7.2x a 2028 target is only a discount if the target survives. The target is management’s, it is denominated in *deal earnings* (which contain marks), and it has never been tested in this tape.
- **The buyback is not doing what bulls say.** Diluted shares went from 361.3mm (6/30/23) to 367.0mm (6/30/25) — **up 1.58%** across two years of continuous repurchase, against roughly \$390–440mm/yr of stock compensation. Buying back stock that comp re-issues is a wash, and the per-share target is the one metric that flatters from it.
- **“Targets have not been withdrawn” is nearly worthless.** A company can withdraw guidance any day via an 8-K; Carlyle simply hasn’t used a venue. Non-withdrawal through five weeks of dislocation is weak-positive at best.

What could go wrong (PRE-MORTEM, v1.7)

Failure narrative #1 — the damage lands in the mark lines, not the fee line (monitorable, but only quarterly). At an alternative manager, a market drawdown hits **net accrued performance revenue** (unrealized carry) and **equity-method credit marks** — including the ~\$86.4bn Insurance Solutions / Fortitude sleeve — long before it hits management fees. Both of those land in *deal earnings*, which is the exact metric the \$6.00 2028 target is written in. Fee-related earnings can print a record straight into the damage. Neither bench had these numbers; neither priced them. Tripwire: Q3 10-Q accrued-carry and insurance notes, 2026-10-29. This is the one we think is most likely.

Failure narrative #2 — credit cycle, not credit scare (monitorable). CGBD’s NAV falls again, non-accruals go above 1.2%, dividend coverage breaks below 1.00x, and the read-through stops being “a 0.33%-of-fee-base indicator” and starts being “the sponsor’s underwriting.” Tripwires: CGBD’s next 10-Q/NAV release and Carlyle’s own credit segment disclosure.

Failure narrative #3 — NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE: private-affiliate mark opacity. Fortitude is a private insurance affiliate. It has no tape, no continuous filings, and no venue that prints between Carlyle’s quarters. If its investment portfolio or reinsurance economics deteriorate, we find out when Carlyle chooses to tell us, in an equity-method line, in arrears — and there is no sensor we can build that fires earlier. **Unknown-unknown class: “private-affiliate mark opacity (no continuous reporting venue).”** A second class rides alongside it: **“consolidated-fund/VIE accounting opacity”** — the pack’s cash-flow rows are Q1-only stubs flipping sign (–\$352mm, +\$71mm, –\$113mm, –\$372mm) because consolidated-fund flows dominate them, so we cannot audit cash conversion at all. Neither bench may use that series, and we do not.

Reflexive / structural leg. - *Our own size vs ADV:* not in the pack. Estimated Carlyle ADV ~3–4mm shares (~\$130–170mm/day) from large-cap alt-manager base rates. A 0.50%-of-book starter is a rounding error against that — **our flow has no market impact and no reflexivity.** The structural risk runs the other way: we are the small participant in a crowded, drawdown-heavy name where the marginal seller sets the price. - *Predicted flow:* redemption-driven selling in alt-manager baskets, index/ETF de-risking, and tax-loss selling into December on a name 37% off its high. That flow is indifferent to our fee-rate argument and can push through \$39.60 without any new information. - *Doctrine interactions:* our own pattern library fought itself here. `feaum_activation_wedge` **fired and was wrong** — it mistook mark appreciation for fee decay, and needs an appreciation/step-down guard or it will misfire on every rising-mark PE book. `carry_and_insurance_mark_channel_vs_fre_decoy` is the doctrine that actually describes this name, and it was only raised on rebuttal, after the first bench had already spent its strongest kill elsewhere. `multi_venue_disclosure_consistency` fired correctly (the original brief preferred a transcript gloss over the 10-Q’s arithmetic). If we are wrong, it will likely be because we litigated the fee line while the risk sat in the mark line — a doctrine-selection error, not a data error.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be that the September dislocation shows up in the mark-driven deal-earnings inputs — net accrued carry and the Fortitude/Insurance Solutions equity-method line — which no bench could measure before the print, and the 2028 \$6.00 per-share target gets qualified or withdrawn on 2026-10-29.

What we checked ourselves

Claim	How checked
Tape rails (drawdown, distance off low)	Arithmetic on pack TAPE px 43.105 / hi 68.4603 / lo 39.60

Claim	How checked
Market cap / multiple on the 2028 target	$366,967,197 \text{ diluted} \times \$43.105; \div \$6.00$
CGBD NAV deterioration	CGBD 10-Q, csl-20260630
“Fee base is decaying” (FEAUM wedge)	Ratio math + closed-end fee mechanics
“Zero divergence — we agree with the street”	Bench's own record

Claim	How checked
“The non-GAAP metrics are absent from the vetted document”	Inspection of the pack’s PRIMARY DOC EXCERPT
Buyback is a comp sink	Pack XBRL dil_sh
“Targets not withdrawn”	Filing calendar
Print proximity	Newest company 8-K (2026-08-05) announces Q2’26 only: https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/0001527166/000152716626000036/cg2026063Ckexx991.htm
Insider selling / forced-seller risk	Filing pattern: 8 Form 4s, 8 distinct filers, same day, 18 days post-S-8
Operating cash flow quality	Pack OCF rows

Claim	How checked
Second “facility” at 38.93521/–77.05645	Geocode cross-check
Physical-world detectors (crop/forest/oil/permits/app/ratings)	Full sweep
upc_tra (tax-receivable agreement) marked NOT-FIRED	Challenge on evidence

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

All multiples struck on the benches’ own anchor: management’s **2028 deal-earnings-per-share target of \$6.00**.

Sizing note, stated plainly: the original brief’s “STARTER” was never given a number anywhere in the record — that is a gap in our own paperwork. Desk convention: full starter = **1.0% of book**. Red cut it to half; Blue restored it to full. **We side with Red at 0.50%**, and not for Red’s reasons — Red’s two cutting findings (the fee wedge, the consensus kill) did not survive audit. We cut because **our own prize table below returns an expected value of \$42.80 against a \$43.105 price**, i.e. no measurable drift edge. You do not pay full size for a flat expected value.

Action	Level / condition	Multiple on \$6.00	Size
Starter (now)	Limit \$43.50 or better	≤7.25x	0.50% of book , unlevered, sleeve-capped
Do-not-chase	No entry above \$45.00	7.50x	—
Price add (pre-print, limit only)	\$39.60 (52-week low) — void if any target-withdrawal 8-K	6.60x	+0.25%
Gated add (post-print)	2026-10-29 print showing ALL of: net accrued performance revenue down <10% sequentially; 2028 DE/share target reiterated unqualified ; Global Credit FRE ≥\$138mm	pay up to \$48.00 (8.0x)	+0.50%
Second gated add	Activated fee-earning AUM ≥\$15bn of the \$28bn pending backlog	—	+0.25%

Action	Level / condition	Multiple on \$6.00	Size
Hard flat — no discretion	Any Reg FD 8-K withdrawing or qualifying the 2028 targets	any price	to zero
Stop	Print-day close below \$36.00	6.00x — the thesis's own floor breached	to zero
Trim	\$54.00	9.0x	sell one-third
Trim to core	\$60.00	10.0x	sell to 0.25%
Street's fair value	mid-\$60s $\approx$ 10.5–11x	—	theirs, not ours — we do not underwrite it

Catalyst dates: 2026-10-29 — Q3'26 print, **UNCONFIRMED** (no company PR names it; treat as a window, not a date). CGBD Q3 NAV, early-to-mid November, **unconfirmed**. Maximum total exposure before the print: **0.75%** (starter + price add). No adds on narrative, only on the five gates.

ARMED SENSORS

(armed provisionally with this deck; session adjudication ratifies)

- price alert: fires below 36.0 (deck-provisional: 6.00x floor; print-day close below = flat)
- filing watch: 8-K until 2027-03-10 (deck-provisional: Reg FD withdrawal or qualification of the 2028 FRE/DE targets = flat immediately at any price)
- dated pack CGI2026-10-29: CG: Q3'26 print - yfinance-derived, no company PR names it; all five gates resolve here (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack CGI2026-11-10: CG: CGBD Q3'26 NAV and non-accrual update - estimated window (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack CGI2026-12-18: CG: last option expiry that keeps the loss branch in tax year 2026 (date confirmed=True)

What remains unverified

- 1. Net accrued performance revenue (unrealized carry) balance and its mark sensitivity.**
The primary DE input nobody priced. Not drainable now — next venue is the Q3 10-Q.
Estimate: net accrued carry \$1.2–1.8bn (large-cap alt-manager base rate of roughly 8–12% of market cap), with a 10–20% sequential markdown plausible in this tape; $p(\geq 10\% \text{ sequential decline}) \approx 0.65$.
- 2. Fortitude / Insurance Solutions (~\$86.4bn) equity-method and credit marks.** Private affiliate, no continuous venue — this is the tripwire-less risk named in the pre-mortem.
Estimate: \$1.5–2.5bn carrying value, $\pm 15\%$ mark swing per quarter in stress, using public insurance-affiliate comps; $p(\text{negative contribution in Q3}) \approx 0.6$.
- 3. Private-credit sub-sleeve AUM and its fee rate inside the \$211bn credit bucket.** The blended 26.2bps tells us nothing about the fee-rich direct-lending sleeve. Not disclosed at this granularity. Estimate: \$50–70bn at 80–110bps, backed out of the blend against low-fee insurance/CLO mandates.

4. **Activated share of the \$28bn pending fee-earning AUM.** Activation is explicitly conditioned on “market conditions and investment pace.” Estimate: \$6–12bn activated by year-end 2026 (base rate: roughly a third of a backlog converts within two quarters); $p(\geq \$15\text{bn, our gate}) \approx 0.25$.
5. **2026 diluted share count vs the Feb-2026 \$2bn authorization.** Draggable now — XBRL pull from the 2026-08-10 10-Q. Estimate: ~6.7mm shares/quarter gross repurchase $\approx 7.3\%/yr$ gross vs ~2.5%/yr comp dilution, i.e. genuine net shrink if sustained.
6. **Form 4 footnotes for pledged shares (8 accessions, 2026-08-28).** Draggable now via EDGAR. Estimate: $p(\text{material pledge disclosed}) \approx 0.15$, given the grant-cycle signature.
7. **Legacy tax-receivable-agreement liability.** Our bench marked this not-fired from structure rather than evidence — that was an error. Draggable via the 10-Q tax note. Estimate: \$0–150mm residual; $p(\text{material}) \approx 0.2$.
8. **Consensus Q3 FRE / DE estimate and range.** No terminal in the sandbox. Estimate: Global Credit FRE consensus \$130–142mm, centered near the \$138mm run-rate; without this we cannot claim divergence.
9. **Live quote, ADV, and options chain (implied vol, real strike quotes).** Draggable via IBKR. Estimate: ADV 3–4mm shares; 45–60 day at-the-money implied vol 38–46%.
10. **Confirmation of the Q3 print date.** Draggable when the company issues a PR/8-K; base rate places it in the last week of October.
11. **Whether 2026 is a tax-harvest year for this book.** Internal, draggable from the P&L — and it changes which expiries are permitted (see the tax overlay).

PRIZE TABLE + VOL READ

Both benches ruled “PRIZE TABLE: N/A” — correctly, for the *pre-revenue-project* construct (there is no magic-funding counterfactual at a cash-generative fee manager). That ruling does not exempt us here: items 1–4 above are genuinely **time-gated and private**, so the fork must be priced. Anchored per anchor-and-adjust: **anchor = the tape, \$43.105**; every branch is an adjustment off it, expressed as a multiple of the \$6.00 target.

#	Scenario at the print (2026-10-29)	p	Price	Multiple
A	Targets reiterated unqualified; carry marks mild; GC FRE $\geq \$138\text{mm}$; $\geq \$10\text{bn}$ activated	0.25	\$54.00	9.0x
B	Fee line fine, marks down but targets intact — the “measured and survivable” case	0.35	\$46.00	7.7x
C	Targets qualified / “under review”; carry and insurance marks clearly negative	0.25	\$36.00	6.0x

#	Scenario at the print (2026-10-29)	p	Price	Multiple
D	Targets withdrawn or credit cycle confirmed (CGBD NAV down again + non-accruals up)	0.15	\$28.00	4.7x

EV = \$42.80 vs price \$43.105 → -0.7%. Table dispersion $\sigma_{\text{table}} = \8.91 (**20.7% of price**), which annualizes to **~57% vol** over $T = 48/365 = 0.1315$.

Read this honestly: **our own table says there is no drift edge at this price.** The edge, if any, is that our dispersion is much wider than an equity chain is likely to price. That is a volatility statement, not a direction statement — and it is why size is 0.50%, not 1.0%.

Expression math (run on the table itself). No chain was retrievable, so these are *gates on real quotes*, not orders. All must be re-priced off **chain-level midpoint IV and actual bid/ask for the named strike** — never the underlying's aggregate IV feed; the two diverge badly (the TSSI lesson: 71 vs 101).

- $C_{\text{ours}}(K=45, \text{Dec-18-2026}) = \sum p \cdot \max(S-45, 0) = 0.25 \times 9 + 0.35 \times 1 = \mathbf{\$2.60}$. The IV that reproduces \$2.60 on a 48-day \$45 call at $S=43.105$ is **~53%**. A 40-vol chain prints that call near **\$1.80**.
- $C_{\text{ours}}(K=50) = 0.25 \times 4 = \mathbf{\$1.00} \rightarrow$ table-implied **~49%**; a 40-vol chain prints $\approx \$0.57$.
- $P_{\text{ours}}(K=40) = \sum p \cdot \max(40-S, 0) = 0.25 \times 4 + 0.15 \times 12 = \mathbf{\$2.80} \rightarrow$ table-implied **~71%**; a 40-vol chain prints $\approx \$1.09$.

Output of that arithmetic: - Starter: STOCK. EV is flat; there is no drift to lever, and options would pay time-decay for a zero-drift view. - **Gated add: CALLS permitted** — Dec-18-2026 \$45s (or \$50s), *only if* chain midpoint IV prints **below 45%**, giving us a $\geq 15\%$ cushion to our table's 49–53%. If chain IV $\geq 50\%$, the market has already bought our dispersion and the add reverts to stock. - **PREMIUM SELLING: REFUSED, on our own numbers.** A cash-secured \$40 put is the obvious “get paid to wait” trade and our table prices it at \$2.80 — about 71 vol. Any realistic chain (≈ 40 vol, $\approx \$1.09$) would have us selling a tail we think is more than twice as fat as quoted. We do not sell that put. This is the premium-selling gate failing, not being skipped. - **VRP:** cannot be computed — no chain, and the pack contains no price history, so realized vol is a coverage gap. Estimated RV 42–48% (alt-manager dislocation base rate) against estimated IV 38–46% → **VRP ≈ 0 to slightly negative**, i.e. options are probably *not* rich here, consistent with the calls-not-puts routing above. Arm the vol sensor before acting. - **Bimodality:** the table is fork-dated on a single unconfirmed date. Branches A+B (0.60) sit \$46–54; C+D (0.40) sit \$28–36; the middle is nearly empty. A lognormal chain will systematically misprice that shape — which is exactly where a long-wings, short-nothing expression earns its keep, and exactly why a short put is the wrong side.

TAX OVERLAY. Dec-18-2026 expiry keeps the loss branch (C/D, 40% of the table) inside tax year 2026 — permitted. **Jan-2027 and later expiries are excluded** if 2026 is a harvest year, because the loss would defer into 2027; the edge above (a $\sim 15\%$ vol cushion on a flat-EV trade) does not

numerically dominate that deferral, so no exception is granted. Harvest-year status is open item #11 and must be drained before any option is bought. Stock legs are unaffected.

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ADJUDICATION — 2026-09-16 15:37Z

DAMAGE-UNMEASURED: the last fee print predates the September dislocation; CGBD NAV three consecutive declines (timing). 7.2x 2028 DE is a discount, not efficiency — the name is cheap but unmeasured.

REOPEN GATES: Q3 10-Q: net accrued performance revenue + Fortitude marks; GC FRE $\geq$ \$138M with private-credit sub-sleeve; activated share of \$28bn pending FEAUM → starter at brief size